

DE-STRESS TO IMPRESS

FOR ESTABLISHING A GREAT STARTUP YOU NEED TO COME UP WITH AN IDEA. HERE ARE SOME PROVEN TECHNIQUES TO HELP YOU IDEATE

By Nachiket Mhatre

It's said that the human brain may not have any iota of muscle fibre in it, but it still tends to behave like a muscle to some degree. Like the weak and practically useless muscles of a new-born human child, the infant brain is a smoother and tiny version of the large and wrinkled adult brain. Just like a muscle, the brain needs exercise for growth. A child's overactive imagination makes it rapidly expand and fold upon itself forming wrinkles and dramatically increasing the grey matter. And again much like a muscle, the brain tends to get fatigued with overuse.

This isn't just a minor inconvenience, but a big problem. That's especially the case in an age where billion dollar corporate entities are erected from the foundation of winning ideas. While brain fatigue or mental block may be a non-issue for a regular blue-collar worker, it has much serious implications in the cutthroat world of startups. Anything that impedes the startup think tank is a matter of serious concern in an economy that's driven by ideas and deals in the currency of innovations.

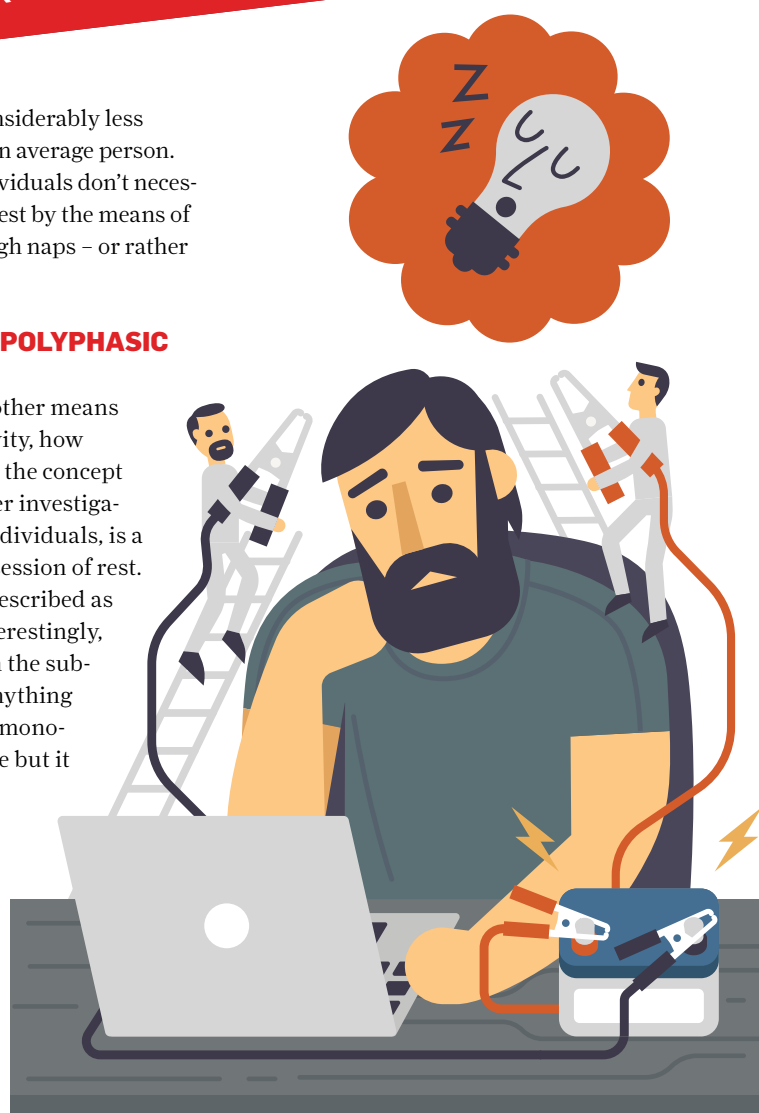
The good news is that although the brain behaves in ways similar to muscles, reinvigorating the soft grey mass of jelly floating about in the cranium thankfully isn't a one-track affair like its muscular counterpart. Rest is the ultimate reset switch that replenishes creative juices, but it isn't the only means of doing that. That's a godsend considering how most over-

achievers tend to get considerably less amount of sleep than an average person. These resourceful individuals don't necessarily tend to achieve rest by the means of sleep, but rather through naps – or rather power naps.

RESTING SMART: POLYPHASIC SLEEP CYCLES

Before we dissect the other means of rejuvenating creativity, how the pioneers approach the concept of rest warrants further investigation. Sleep, for most individuals, is a single uninterrupted session of rest. This is academically described as monophasic sleep. Interestingly, research conducted on the subject reveals that like anything large and continuous, monophasic sleep is effective but it isn't quite efficient.

Military research groups belonging to various countries as well as NASA – or in other words, any organisation with a pressing need to squeeze the most amount of productivity in the least amount of time – have found that polyphasic sleep significantly reduces the amount of time lost to rest. This approach to sleep essentially splits it into a multiple short naps with a view to minimise the total time spent sleeping. Tests with various



versions of polyphasic sleep cycles ranging from four to just two hours of total sleep, showed no noticeable decrease in mental alertness or memory capability when compared to a normal eight-hour monophasic sleep cycle.